



S-Move Dealer

Sponsored Sidebar, Votes & Hearts

Rankings · Sponsors · Donations · Supporters

*Design specification — the agreed model, end to end.
Ready to become build tickets.*

“Our sponsors can’t buy their rank. Only your love moves them up.”

The honesty USP — every mechanism in this document exists to protect it.

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1 Guiding principle

Businesses can't buy their rank — and neither can anyone else. Money buys *presence* (a slot in the sidebar) and *warm recognition* (hearts, a supporters wall), but never *position*. Ranking is earned purely from relevance, location and genuine customer love. This is the honesty USP, and every decision in this document is built to protect it.

The separation is the backbone of the whole design: all ranking-affecting mechanics are either free or earned; all money-driven mechanics (subscription, donations, hearts, supporters wall) are presence or recognition only, and never move a business up the results.

2 The model at a glance

Piece	What it is	Touches ranking?
Sponsored sidebar	Flat monthly subscription to appear in the sidebar	No — presence only
New-scene boost	New sponsor launches at top, fades to earned rank over ~14 days	Yes (temporary, decaying)
Earned score	Always-on views baseline + heavy monthly Votes	Yes — this is the rank
Vote (free token)	One per customer per month, backs a favourite	Yes — $\approx 1000\times$ a view
Free→sponsor	Free business carries earned cred into the sidebar + debut boost	Yes (the cred it earned)
Donation (beggar's hat)	One-off or recurring gift — nothing given in return	No
Heart	Free cosmetic appreciation token, given to <i>all</i> customers	No — never
Supporters wall	Opt-in public recognition of donors (three sections)	No

Two distinct **free** customer tokens, deliberately named apart — **both are free to every customer** (see §6 for why Hearts must not be tied to donating):

- **Vote** — free, monthly, moves the sidebar ranking. Everyone gets one.
- **Heart** — free, monthly allowance, purely cosmetic appreciation. Doesn't move anything.

3 Sidebar ranking — the scoring model

The sidebar reuses the same **location tiering** as the main grid (softSort in routes/items.js): the customer's town floats to tier 0, region to tier 1, everywhere else to tier 2. Within each tier, sponsors are ordered by score:

```
sidebar_score(t) = earned_score
                  + scene_boost x decay(t)

earned_score    = monthly_views + (monthly_votes x VOTE_WEIGHT)
VOTE_WEIGHT     = 1000    (config-tunable, see 3.3)
decay(t)       = 1.0 on registration -> 0.0 over ~14 days
scene_boost    = large enough to clear the top slot on day 0
```

3.1 The “new on the scene” boost

- A newly registered sponsor launches **at the top** of its location tier.
- The boost is **additive and fades to zero over ~14 days**, so the sponsor glides down to its *earned* position — never below it. No cliff, no artificial yank-down. “Decays to the value they’ve earned” = the only thing above earned rank was the fading bonus.
- **Decaying, not a hard pin** — if several sponsors register in the same fortnight they share the top zone (ordered by recency) and slide down gracefully as real signal accrues.
- The boost is an **opportunity, not a handout**: a fortnight of prime visibility to *earn* views and votes. Connect and you stay high on merit; don’t and you settle to your true level.

3.2 Votes (the free monthly token)

- One Vote per verified customer account per month; backs one business (sponsor **or not** — see §4).
- Weighted heavily (≈1000 views) so the customers who bother are decisive, while passive views keep the sidebar alive even when few vote — this solves the empty-field / small-base problem.
- **Carry over by default, prompt to reconfirm/change each month** — the login loop without the friction.
- Monthly **reset for ranking** (fresh board, no permanent incumbents); keep a lifetime tally for a possible “all-time favourite” badge.

3.3 VOTE_WEIGHT is a config knob, not a hardcode

Store it in an `accountant_settings`-style config row so it can be tuned without a redeploy. Start at **1000** (few votes → tokens should dominate). As the base grows and hundreds of votes are cast, dial it down so a handful of votes can’t bury a shop with thousands of genuine views. Watch, tune.

3.4 Anti-gaming (essential at 1000×)

At 1000× a single fake account = a thousand views of influence, so the guards are load-bearing:

- **One Vote per verified customer account.**
- **Local-weighting** — a Musselburgh vote for a Musselburgh shop counts full; an out-of-area vote counts less. Stops a shop rallying random accounts.

4 Vote for any business + the conversion hook

Votes and views accrue to **every** business, sponsor or not, so a free business builds a track record. When it converts to a sponsor it enters the sidebar **carrying its earned cred AND getting the debut boost on top** — honour what they earned *and* give a fair launch moment, so becoming a sponsor always feels rewarding on day one.

“You’ve earned 40 votes and 3,000 views this month as a free listing — become a sponsor and you’d be #2 in Musselburgh right now.”

Their earned popularity is the thing they pay to cash in. The hearts and votes make the sales case for you.

5 Donations — the beggar’s hat

Funds the “free forever for local business” promise. **A donation is a genuine gift — the donor receives nothing in return.** This is not just ethos; it is the load-bearing VAT decision (§12): a gift with nothing given back is *outside the scope of VAT*, so it carries no VAT and does not count toward SMT’s VAT threshold. That is why Hearts are decoupled and free to all (§6) — the instant a donation “buys” something, it becomes a taxable supply.

- **One-off and recurring**, both on the existing Stripe account. Recurring reuses the same subscription plumbing built for sponsors (\$8).
- Copy (honest to the stage — see 5.3): *“Help us keep Dealer free for your local shops — chip in to the upkeep.”*
- Donation state is **tracked and shown on the customer’s account** — a gentle thank-you / chip-in-again nudge. **No reward, no tier, no return benefit.**

5.1 The Supporters wall — the main recognition (opt-in)

Recognition, not a reward token, is what motivates giving — and it is VAT-safe (a simple acknowledgement of a *consumer* donor is not a supply). The wall has **three sections**:

- **Recurring supporters — top billing.** The reliable backbone; a distinct **“Monthly Supporter”** badge. Placed first, which also nudges one-off givers to step up into it.
- **Named single donations.** One-off givers who opted to be named.
- **Anonymous supporters — shown as a count only** (“...joined by 142 anonymous supporters”). Can’t be named; still powerful breadth.
- **Never rank within a section by amount** — a money-sorted list reads as a rich-list and is off-brand. Order alphabetically or most-recent-first (most-recent keeps it looking live).
- Opt-in only: a `public_supporter` flag + chosen `supporter_display_name`. Anonymous is the default.

5.2 Display supporter *numbers*, never money raised

Show the headcount of supporters; never show a running £ total. Two reasons:

- **Donor psychology.** A big £ figure triggers *“they don’t need my money”* (the free-rider effect — the top reason donations fall when a cause looks funded), makes an individual’s £5 feel trivial, and — for a company, not a charity — invites *“why are they begging if they’ve raised £X?”*. A **headcount** gives the social proof (*“3,400 supporters keep Dealer free”*) with none of these downsides: people *count* reads as “join the movement,” not “the pot is full.”
- **Two-audience dynamic.** Showing customers handing over *money* makes business sponsors grudge paying (*“why am I paying when customers fund it free?”*). But the supporter **headcount** does the opposite — it’s a *selling point to businesses*: proof of an engaged, loyal audience worth advertising to. Headcount = win-win; £-value = pure risk.
- Add a **“this month”** count beside any lifetime figure, so it always looks live and joinable.

5.3 The donation ask must age with the business (honesty)

“Donations are vital to our survival” is true and honest **early**, when few businesses pay. It stops being honest once the business is profitable with paying sponsors. **Plan to soften the copy as the revenue mix shifts** — early “help us survive” → later “help keep the core free for local shops.” Crying poverty while running a thriving platform would breach the honesty principle; don’t leave stale desperate copy up.

6 Hearts — free cosmetic appreciation (decoupled from money)

A ♥ **142** badge sits on any business, **sponsor or not, and never affects ranking** — pure social proof of community appreciation.

6.1 Hearts are FREE for every customer — and must stay that way

Hearts are not bought and are not a donation reward. Every customer gets a small **monthly Heart allowance** (like the Vote) to hand out, whether or not they have ever donated.

The tiered “donate £5, get 2 Hearts” idea was REJECTED — on VAT grounds.

Pricing Hearts = “something given in return” = every donation becomes a taxable supply: VAT on every £1, and the income counts toward SMT’s VAT threshold. Free-to-all Hearts keep donations a genuine gift — outside scope, no threshold impact, nothing to tear out when SMT registers. Do not reintroduce.

- Give all customers a modest **monthly allowance** so Hearts stay *scarce and meaningful* — not unlimited, or they lose value.
- The customer **holds a pot of unspent Hearts** and allocates them freely — one business or spread around. **Stacking on a favourite is allowed** (harmless — no rank effect; let superfans be superfans).

6.2 Two counters

- **Lifetime cumulative** — a permanent, growing badge of honour (“340 hearts from the community”). Not reset.
- **“This month”** secondary counter (“♥ 14 this month”) — a fresh, tenure-neutral signal so newcomers aren’t visually dwarfed by long-standing shops. Show both.

6.3 Honest wording

Call the badge **“appreciation,”** never “fans” or anything implying a purchase. Since Hearts are free and credit the *business* (not the giver), there is no wallet-domination and nothing to game. Leave uncapped to start; revisit a soft cap only if real data shows a problem.

7 Data model additions

7.1 Sellers table (new columns)

stripe_customer_id	text	
stripe_subscription_id	text	
subscription_status	text	-- active past_due cancelled none
sponsored	boolean	-- derived: sub currently paid & live
sponsored_until	timestampz	
sponsor_since	timestampz	-- new-scene boost decay clock
hearts_lifetime	integer	default 0
hearts_this_month	integer	default 0

7.2 Customers table (new columns)

vote_available	boolean	-- this month's free Vote unused?
hearts_balance	integer	default 0 -- unspent hearts
public_supporter	boolean	default false
supporter_display_name	text	

7.3 New tables

votes	(customer_id, seller_id, month, weight)	unique(customer_id, month)
hearts_given	(customer_id, seller_id, count, created_at)	-- free allowance, not bought
donations	(customer_id, amount, type, stripe_ref, public, created_at)	-- NO reward link
sidebar_config	(vote_weight, scene_boost, boost_days, heart_allowance, ...)	-- tunable

The donations table deliberately has **no** hearts_minted / reward column — donations grant nothing, so the record stays a clean out-of-scope gift (\$12). hearts_balance is topped up by the free monthly allowance, never by a payment. Sidebar query filters sponsored = true, orders by the \$3 score within location tiers; Hearts render on every business card.

8 Payments plumbing (Stripe)

Stripe is already live for one-off item checkout — Checkout Sessions + a webhook at server.js:116 handling checkout.session.completed. This design adds **recurring billing (Stripe Billing / Subscriptions)** on the *same* account.

New webhook endpoint — a separate /api/billing/webhook (keeps subscription events cleanly apart from order-checkout events). Handle:

- invoice.paid → set sponsored=true, sponsored_until=period_end, subscription_status=active
- invoice.payment_failed → subscription_status=past_due, start the grace clock
- customer.subscription.deleted → sponsored=false, drop from sidebar
- **Donations** — one-off via a Checkout Session (mode payment); recurring via a Subscription (mode subscription). On success, record the donation and (if opted in) add the donor to the Supporters wall. **Grant no reward** — Hearts are the free monthly allowance, never minted from a payment.
- **Likely new files:** routes/billing.js (subscription + donation endpoints + webhook), new database.js objects (sellerSubscriptions, votes, heartsGiven, donations).

9 Dunning etiquette (grace before losing the slot)

On-brand, generous, communicative — never a surprise. Removing the slot must never delete *content*.

Day	Action
0	Payment fails. Slot stays live . Friendly note: “card didn’t go through, no rush, here’s the update link.”
1–14	Stripe Smart Retries run automatically. Slot stays live. Reminder ~day 7.
14	Final “we’ll pause your spot on [date]” heads-up.
~21	Grace expires → sponsor drops out of the sidebar . Their shop and every listing stay exactly as any free seller’s.

- **Never remove content — only the sidebar presence.** Aligns with the free-forever core.
- **~14–21 days** is the fair sweet spot: under a week is punitive, over a month gives the premium slot away free.
- **Instant restore** when the failed invoice is paid — the slot returns immediately.

10 Open decisions (small, decidable at build time)

- Boost decay curve — linear vs. ease-out (recommend ease-out so the drop is gentle at the end).
- Exact scene_boost magnitude and VOTE_WEIGHT starting value (1000 recommended) — both config, tune live.
- Local-weighting formula for votes (full-weight local, half-weight out-of-area is a reasonable start).
- Whether to surface the “all-time favourite” lifetime-vote badge in v1 or defer.

11 Build order (suggested)

#	Stage	What it covers
1	Data model	Migrations for §7 — sellers columns, customers columns, new tables, config row.
2	Stripe subscriptions	routes/billing.js, sponsor sub create/cancel, /api/billing/webhook, sidebar sponsored gating.
3	Sidebar ranking	Scoring in the directory/sidebar query, new-scene boost decay, location tiering reuse.
4	Votes	Customer account UI (token available/used), monthly reset job, anti-gaming (verified + local weight).
5	Donations + Hearts	Beggar's-hat UI (one-off + recurring, no reward), free monthly Heart allowance + allocation, heart badges on cards, two counters.
6	Supporters wall	Three sections (recurring / named one-off / anonymous count), opt-in flag, supporter-headcount display (no £ total).
7	Dunning	Reminder emails/SMS, grace clock, auto-drop + instant restore.

12 Revenue model & VAT treatment

The Dealer app is owned and run by **S-Move Technologies Ltd (SMT)**, which is **not VAT-registered yet**. SMT provides the software; **S-Move Removals Ltd (SMR)** is a separate company that *uses* it as the pioneer/development customer. (SMR is VAT-registered in its own right; unrelated to Dealer.) So there is no VAT to charge on Dealer income today — but the model is built VAT-clean so nothing breaks when SMT eventually registers.

12.1 Two revenue categories (the mental model)

- **Support (optional — funds the free platform):** customer **donations** + business **sponsorship**. “Both sides of the coin” support the app.
- **Products / tools (optional — own revenue stream):** **stock control** for businesses — *paying for a tool*, not supporting the app; intended to be the real long-term revenue.

12.2 VAT treatment (the calculator rule)

Marketing framing ≠ VAT treatment. What matters is whether the payer gets something in return:

Income	Something in return?	VAT treatment	Counts to threshold?
Customer donation	No — genuine gift	Outside scope — off the calculator	No
Business sponsorship	Yes — sidebar presence	Taxable supply (std-rated)	Yes
Stock control	Yes — a tool/service	Taxable supply (std-rated)	Yes

Why keep donations out of scope, on purpose: (1) build the feature VAT-clean now, so nothing has to be pulled when SMT registers; (2) genuine gifts don't inflate SMT's taxable turnover, so donations never drag SMT toward the threshold for no reason. The free-to-all Hearts (§6) are exactly what keeps donations “nothing given in return.”

Confirm with the accountant before build — see the companion one-pager.

Key questions: (a) donations sit outside scope under the decoupled model; (b) the Supporters-wall acknowledgement of consumer donors is not a supply; (c) the SMT↔SMR software relationship, and its zero-fee dev-partner basis, reads cleanly.

Money buys presence and recognition — never position. Donations are gifts; sponsorship & stock control are the taxable supplies.

Both separations are the design's backbone. Keep them intact through implementation and the honesty promise holds.